



(clockwise from far left) students of ALLEN Coaching; Pankaj Sijairya, director of Physicswallah Centre; the Unacademy centre in Kota



while continuing to attend classes at ALLEN," says Rashmi Sinha, a higher secondary student from Bihar who is staying in Kota and has enrolled at a top centre for offline coaching even as she takes online classes from another centre. She believes the entry of online companies in offline coaching won't change the situation all that much in the long term. "Landing a computer science seat in an IIT for which millions are competing for a few hundred general seats is anyway like a lottery. Sometimes, I feel that even without these coaching centres, the result would be the same for most students," she says. Coaching centres, however, cite numerous examples of how their courses have helped the poor and those who have had Hindi as the medium of instruction in school to get through IITs and AIIMS.

In June, Unacademy launched two learning centres in Kota and proposes to have more in Jaipur, Ahmedabad, Chandigarh, Patna, Pune, Bengaluru, Delhi and Lucknow within this year. The target is to have a first batch of 15,000 offline students and take the number up to 100,000 in a year across the country. Currently, it claims to have 1,800 students at its just-opened centre in Kota, with 44 educators adding to 92 million learners on its online platform and 800,000 subscribers.

Alakh Pandey of Physicswallah picked Pankaj Sijairya of Pankaj Sir Chemistry fame to set up a centre in Kota. Within weeks, the centre had 8,500 students and plans were in place to open a second one. They are also starting two centres in Delhi and one each in Patna, Kolkata and Kanpur. "As 80 per cent of the students in Kota come from UP and Bihar, we want to go as close to them as possible," says Pandey. Physicswallah began with free YouTube tutorials in 2016 before switching to user-friendly apps in 2020 with packages for Rs 4,000. It had a million users online and yet felt the need to shift to offline coaching.

Resonance CMD R.K. Verma continues to be a believer in offline teaching. Son of a stone-quarry labourer from Kota, Verma graduated from IIT Madras in 1994 and began his teaching career with Bansal classes, a pioneer of coaching in Kota, before setting up his own centre for students from less privileged backgrounds. There are 55,000 students at his centres in Kota and an equal number at 80 other centres in India. "We did online coaching effectively during Covid. It's a matter of time before we know what kind of digital coaching works best and whether to involve some specialised online companies," says Verma, who believes offline coaching is best for students who are "impulsive and need a teacher and a classroom to keep them focused". His focus right now is to match his company's pre-Covid best turnover of Rs 400 crore.

Whatever be the reasons motivating online educational technology companies to enter the world of brick-and-mortar classrooms, they will face tough competition from established coaching centres. If this leads to more options for students to choose from, and better quality at lower prices, there should be no cause for complaint. ■